

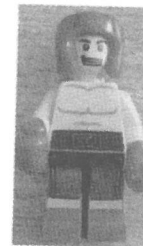
ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

Below is an extract from a blog entry about LEGO:

Are LEGO figures getting angrier?

Nevermind increasingly violent video games or the ever-present danger of an uncensored internet, a far more important and unexpected change is happening that could be affecting children's emotional development. Researchers have discovered that the faces on LEGO Minifigures are becoming increasingly angry and less happy. Combined with a trend towards more war-related LEGO themes, a team led by Christoph Bartneck at the University of Canterbury said, "We cannot help but wonder how this impacts how children play."



The influence of LEGO is huge. The product is sold in more than 130 countries and the company produced more than 36 billion lego bricks in 2010 alone. On average each person on earth owns approximately 75 lego bricks. The vast majority of LEGO figures have happy faces (324), but the next most common is anger (192), followed by sadness (49), disgust (28), surprise (23) and fear (11). And the trend is for an increasing proportion of angry faces, with a reduction in happy faces.

Bartneck's team also observed that LEGO has a considerable range of weapon systems in their products and that the company is moving towards more war-based play themes. Together with the rising numbers of angry faces, the researchers warned that LEGO might not be able to hold onto its highly positive reputation. The children that grow up with LEGO today will remember not only smileys, but also anger and fear in the Minifigures' faces.

Your teacher wants you to do a project about the impact of LEGO on young people. You may want to talk about:

- whether LEGO is popular among young people
- reasons for its popularity compared to other toys
- pros and cons of playing with LEGO figures with different faces
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. What toys did you play with when you were small?
2. Do you think playing with LEGO is fun?
3. Would you like to play with war-based LEGO?
4. Do you think LEGO is more popular with boys than girls?
5. Why does LEGO appeal to adults as well as children?
6. Should schools use LEGO in class?
7. Should there be an age restriction for war-based LEGO figures?
8. What challenges do you think LEGO is facing?